Exhibition Design and Floorplan: Museum of Theft

Team: Biscuit

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1. Supporting Exhibition Elements

1.1. Audio Guide:

Visitors will access the audio guide via QR codes placed at the entrance and beside key exhibits. Rather than repeating the wall text, the guide provides historical context and prompts visitors to reflect on the museum's core themes.

It opens with the central question "what makes an act of taking count as theft?" and tracks the exhibition's three sections:

1. Who is called a thief?
2. What can be taken?
3. Who has the authority to define and narrate the act?

Selected case studies will feature short audio commentaries on specific artifacts, supplemented where appropriate by archival audio (such as Robin Hood ballad excerpts or Hasdeo Arand protest recordings). To keep the shared gallery quiet and allow self-paced viewing, audio will play directly on visitors' personal devices. All recordings and transcripts will also be archived in the digital catalogue.

1.2. Digital Catalogue & Source Archive:

A digital catalogue will accompany the physical exhibition, serving as both an extension of the limited gallery space and a digital archive that will remain accessible after the exhibition. Organized along the same three-section structure, each case study entry will include:

- Object descriptions, contextual essays, and high-resolution images (distinguishing originals from reproductions).
- Links to primary archival sources, historical texts, research papers, and government documents so visitors can inspect the evidence firsthand.
- Embedded audio guide recordings alongside full written transcripts.

Accessible via QR codes at the entrance and at individual display, this archive reflects the exhibition's focus on who owns and frames history, ensuring the research, materials, and questions remain publicly available long after the physical museum closes.

1.3 Pushpins on a Voting Strip:

Each major case study will be accompanied by a horizontal voting strip mounted, running from 0 ("Not theft") to 10 ("Theft"). Visitors place a pushpin at the point they feel the case sits. The strip is continuous rather than binary because most cases in the exhibition do not resolve cleanly and forcing a yes-or-no verdict would misrepresent the material the visitor has just read.

The strips are openly visible. Each visitor sees the existing distribution before placing their own pin, which reliably produces clustering. To make the effect legible, a few pins will be placed on each strip before opening.

Strips will be photographed at the close of each day and the distributions reproduced in the digital catalogue alongside the corresponding case study, so that the visitors' own judgments become part of the archived record rather than being discarded with the gallery.

2. Planned Exhibits and Sourcing

2.1: Who is the thief?

1. **Ordinary theft**
    - *Physical Items:* A wallet, imitation cash, debit and credit cards, and artificial jewellery to represent an ordinary theft.
    - *Video:* A short staged surveillance-style recording depicting contrasting treatment of shoplifting incidents across social classes. The recording will be identified as a reconstruction.
    - *Printed Items:* Historical material on kleptomania and a comparison of differing legal or social responses to theft. Authentic case records will be used where available; any illustrative reconstructions will be clearly labelled.
    - *Panel*: Highlight the key points around kleptomania, and how ordinary theft goes about.
    - *Budget*: ~200 INR.
2. **The outlaw (Robin Hood)**
    - *Printed Items:* Extracts from historical Robin Hood ballads, illustrations from different periods and film posters.
    - *Additional Audio options:* Selected ballad excerpts, accessible through the audio guide.
    - *Optional souvenir:* Miniature Robin Hood hats made from coloured paper.
    - *Panel:* A tale of the deeds of Robin Hood and how they changed over time with keen focus on the perception of society towards the folk hero.
    - *Budget*: ~150 INR.
3. **The Benin Bronzes**
    - *Physical Items:* A replica or handmade representation of a selected Benin Bronze, if feasible. An enlarged printed image will serve as an alternative.

- *Printed documents*: News articles and records concerning the removal and restitution of the Benin Bronzes, also a map indicating the movement of the objects from Benin to overseas collections, based on available provenance records.
- *Panel:* A concise coverage on the case of the Benin Bronzes spanning from their origin to the newer perspectives brought out by people in the post-colonial period.
- Budget: ~200 INR

2.2: What can be taken?

1. Rubber

- *Physical Items:* Rubber seeds if available (~250 INR), otherwise Castor seeds (~80 INR)
- *Printed Story panel:* The transfer of rubber seeds by Henry Wickham in 1876 and its historical consequences.
- *Printed Items:* A Map: Brazil → Kew → Ceylon and Southeast Asia, an account of the transfer from the British perspective, placed alongside a later Brazilian interpretation, labels for identification and explanation of the displayed specimen.
- Budget: ~300 INR

2. Havasupai Blood Samples

- *Physical Items:* An unused blood-collection tube, clearly labelled as a demonstration object.
- *Printed story panel and map:* The Havasupai Tribe, its location, and the history of the research beginning in 1990.
- *Printed flow diagram:* BLOOD → DNA → DATA → ANCESTRY, illustrating how the samples produced additional information.
- *Printed consent panel:* Havasupai participants' own statements about what they understood the research to be for (attributed to the original sources), set beside the documented consent arrangements, closing with the 2010 settlement and its limits: the samples could be returned, but information already produced from them could not.
- *Budget: ~400 INR*

3. Clearview AI

- *Digital demonstration:* A tablet or laptop runs a simulated facial-recognition search on a consenting volunteer, matching one photo to three staged photos of them in different settings, POSTED → COLLECTED → FACE DATA → SEARCHABLEas well in the demonstration.
- *Printed comparison panel:* "Posted publicly" versus "Agreed to this use".
- *Printed regulatory documents:* Selected findings and dated rulings concerning Clearview AI, with their legal status verified before display.
- *Printed story panel:* Contrasting arguments concerning publicly available photographs, biometric information and surveillance.
- *Budget: ~100 INR*

2.3: Who Names the Act and Who Owns the Story?

1. **The Dawes General Allotment Act (1887)**
    - *Physical Items:* A rubber stamp reading “SURPLUS” and an ink pad, used on a mock allotment ledger. A vintage surveyor’s chain or compass if available, otherwise an enlarged photograph.
    - *Printed Items:* The 1911 “Indian Land for Sale” poster issued by the Department of the Interior advertising 350,000 acres of “surplus” land (Library of Congress). The original 1887 statute text and sample allotment ledger pages (National Archives). The 1900 Cherokee Nation memorial to Congress protesting forced allotment (govinfo). Reproductions will be labelled as such.
    - *Printed map:* Original treaty territory set against land held after allotment, showing the loss of roughly 90 million acres. Displayed as a sequence of dated maps so the transfer reads as a process rather than a single event.
    - *Placard:* A single passage from an anti-allotment speech or petition, formatted as a museum label and attributed to its original source.
    - *Panel:* How communal land was reclassified as individual plots and then as surplus, and how the paperwork that authorised it reads as ordinary administration rather than seizure.
    - Budget: ~300 INR.
2. **The Hasdeo Arand Forest (present day)**
    - *Physical Items:* A pot with plant(s), and a paper cutout of a person hugging the plant.
    - *Printed Items:* Excerpts from the Adani Foundation CSR report (2023–24) and the Adani Enterprises ESG report (2023) covering Chhattisgarh operations. The official forest clearance notice for the Parsa East and Kete Basan blocks. Gram Sabha resolutions from Ghatbarra, Salhi and Hariharpur refusing consent under the Forest Rights Act (2006) and PESA (1996). Protest photographs from the Hasdeo Bachao Andolan, used with permission or credited editorial reference only.
    - *Printed map:* Forest cover against allocated coal blocks, with village locations marked.
    - *Audio Clip:* Forest and protest recordings, accessible through the audio guide.
    - *Panel:* The same forest described as a cleared block in one archive and as refused land in another, and what happens when both records are formally valid.
    - Budget: ~250 INR.

3. **Provisional Floor Layout**

